Nagaland in 2018. If the BJP had not been able to achieve a ‘Congress-mukt’ Bharat, it seemed to be moving towards a ‘Congress-mukt’ Northeast, even if it was not winning outright. Furthermore, its wipe-out of the CPI(M) government in Agartala was its first-ever victory in a direct election face-off with the Left. The Marxist party had held power for over two decades continuously in the state.

To the party, the Tripura victory in particular meant that the geographical Kurukshetra of the great ideological battles that have defined the Republic since its inception—between the red Left and the saffron Right—had been remapped. Sunil Deodhar, the BJP’s Tripura in-charge, exulted: ‘We have cultivated “kesar” [saffron] in the red desert’ and ‘broken the Communist spine’.[21] The BJP saw here portents for possible realignments in Kerala, the one other state where the Left still rules. ‘The biggest happiness today is with our Kerala and West Bengal colleagues,’ Amit Shah declared on the day of the Northeast victories. ‘It is now proven that Left is not right for any part of India. This has been decided first in West Bengal, now in Tripura.’[22] Modi was even more ecstatic, emphasising the point with triumphant imagery: ‘*Jab sooraj dhalta hai to laal rang dikhta hai, aur jb ugta hai to kesariya rang hota hai* [When the sun sets, it is red in colour, and when it rises, it is saffron]’.[23] This was received with thunderous applause at the BJP office.

So, how did the party turn its fortunes around in the Northeast? Locally led by erstwhile foes, like ex-Congress leader Himanta Biswa Sarma, who drove an aggressive policy of mergers, acquisitions and alliances with regional power groups; pushed by its central leadership’s aggressive expansion strategy; supported by a growing network of RSS shakhas in the region; and riding a cycle of anti-incumbency with the Congress in these states, the BJP upended conventional Northeast politics between 2016 and 2019. This chapter examines whether the shift is a passing one, dependent on the BJP’s control of Delhi, or whether it reflects a subterranean churning in the Northeast.